

Dry weather

Some countries have plenty of water and shortages are rare. However, in some parts of the world water is scarce, and people can never be sure when it will rain next. Droughts happen when for months—or even years—on end, the Earth's surface loses more water than it collects. In some places, called deserts, rain hardly ever falls at all.

Drought

If droughts last for a very long time, animals die of thirst, crops wither in the hot Sun, and people have to go without food—they may even die of starvation.



*Parched,
cracked land*

*In true deserts,
plants and
animals can only
live near oases,
which are areas
of open water.*

Desert scene

You'll often find deserts inland, next to mountain ranges. The mountains act as a shield and keep rain-bearing clouds away. Semideserts like this one in Arizona, in the United States, have a little rainfall—enough to support plants that can store water, like cacti.

